NEHAL WADHERA, 25

Punjab Kings

MATCHES: 16 RUNS: 369
AVERAGE: 30.75 STRIKE RATE: 145.85

Nehal Wadhera cut his teeth with MI in 2023, but then had a quiet 2024. After donning the PBKS jersey for IPL 2025, though, the 25-year-old southpaw has been shredding attacks with gusto, unerringly good on the leg side and behind the stumps (for proof, check his 70 off 37 balls versus Rajasthan Royals in Jaipur). Wadhera could play a calm hand too, like in the game against RCB, where he skimmed 33 off 24 balls. He might cop some blame for the failure in the final, but he was one of the rockets that propelled PBKS there. —*SV*



REUTERS



There's something about a raw, left-arm fast-bowling talent that bewitches the eye, and Mumbai Indians' scouts picked a real pistol when they snapped up Ashwani Kumar. Let loose on the Kolkata Knight Riders on his IPL debut, Ashwani broke their batting spine, scalping Ajinkya Rahane, Manish Pandey, Rinku Singh and Andre Russell with a 4/24 effort. A classical bowling action, enough variations and a left-armer's unnerving angle have stood him in good stead. In the death overs, he held his nerve, complementing stalwarts Jasprit Bumrah and Trent Boult. Although he went for runs in the second qualifier against Punjab Kings, the pacer from Punjab has shown enough promise to keep the MI grandees interested. Ashwani is still a work in progress, but being part of MI means that his stock will continue to rise. In the galleries at Wankhede, they say that youth backed by MI break through and breach the ranks of the Men in Blue. Ashwani will have to make good his promise if he dreams of joining Bumrah, Hardik and Krunal Pandya. —*SV*

ASHWANI KUMAR, 24

Mumbai Indians

MATCHES: 7 WICKETS: 11
ECONOMY: 11.3 S/R: 11.2